

**SLOGANS
RAISED
DURING RAHUL
GANDHI'S
BIRTHDAY
BASH
MAY LEAD THE
CONGRESS
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THE SANGH
PARIVAR.**

LUCKNOW | Theme Parties

Rahul Gandhi's 39th birthday seems to have led the Congress into an ideological battle. Cultural anthropologist Badri Narayan noted that two slogans raised on the occasion—Samajik Samrasta Diwas (social harmony day) and Samrasta Bhoj (community feasts for Dalits)—were taken from the Sangh Parivar's books. Congress leaders, particularly those from the upper castes, went to Dalit villages for com-



CAKE-CUTTING TIME AND IT'S RAHUL EVERYWHERE

munity feasts, again a Sangh Parivar concept. PCC chief spokesperson Akhilesh Singh shoots down the parallels that are being drawn. "We don't believe in false slogans and lip-service," he says. *by Farzand Ahmed*

BANGALORE | Cheap Frills

Commuting in Karnataka is now a luxurious affair and that too at a reasonable price. The Karnataka State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) has deployed an air-conditioned Mercedes-Benz bus. Public transport is the best option, notes Transport Minister R. Ashoka, who inaugurated the Rs 65-lakh world standard bus Bangalore-Mysore Benz bus service. "A luxurious ride should not be limited to just a few people alone," says KSRTC Managing Director Gaurav Gupta.

by Stephen David



CHIRANJEEVI

A PRASHAR RAO

HYDERABAD | Script Gone Awry

His stint in Telugu films may be the stuff dreams are made of, but the same can't be said about Chiranjeevi's Praja Rajyam Party (PRP). Several leaders who helped build the semblance of an organisation for the party now find that there is no attempt to create a structure and network for PRP. While Dr P. Mitra, a Chiranjeevi acolyte, called it quits, another disillusioned activist, Dr P. Vinay Kumar, has resumed work at his clinic. Making it worse is Chiranjeevi's inability to alter the growing perception of the PRP being "a film production company".

by Amarnath K. Menon

A SHORTAGE OF AVIATION FUEL HAS TAKEN ITS TOLL ON 15 PRIVATE FLYING ACADEMIES

DELHI | Yearning to Fly

First the downturn in aviation, now a squeeze on fuel. Fifteen private flying academies in northern India are currently facing an acute shortage of 100 LL aviation fuel because of sluggish supply from Indian Oil. The state-owned oil firm imports the special fuel and brings it into just two centralised depots, one at Kanpur and the second at Nashik. Not only do the academies have to send tankers all the way to source fuel but there is no guarantee of getting enough. The quotas have shrunk by up to 50 per cent per school, seriously impacting flight training. "We are flying only 250 hours a month, less than half our regular quota. This means longer waits for our students to get their pilot licences," says a flying school owner.

by Sandeep Unnithan



MANY DREAMS ARE GROUNDED OVER A SHORTAGE OF FUEL

MANDAR DEODHAR